recognize India's illegal annexation of Sikkim and that it supports the people of Sikkim in their just struggle for national independence and sovereignty and against Indian expansion.' [12] This position was reiterated on 29 April 1975, the day after Sikkim acceded to the Union of India. Thus, an issue that China had claimed was not a subject for discussion between India and China, now became a bone of contention between them.

The Chinese were conscious that they were the only country that refused to recognize the merger as legitimate. However, China is never shy of standing alone on any matter that it deems to be of core interest, until it has weighed all the consequences. In an interview given by Deng Xiaoping to Krishna Kumar, the Editor of *Vikrant* magazine, in Beijing in June 1980, he said, 'We are opposed to the elimination of one sovereign state by another country. But we are not in a position to raise this question now.' [13] This sounded similar to Zhou Enlai's statement during the 1954 Tibet talks, that both sides should only take up issues ripe for settlement. Sikkim, therefore, became a card for the Chinese to be played to advantage when the opportunity presented itself, possibly even as a part of the so-called 'package deal' on the boundary question.

That chance was to come after India–China relations were normalized following the visit of Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in December 1988. The Government of India pressed hard upon the Chinese side to recognize the accession of Sikkim to India. In February 1990, when the minority government of Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar was in office, China's Foreign Minister Qian Qichen told External Affairs Minister Vidya Charan Shukla that China's public silence over Sikkim for several years in spite of its firm opposition to the 'illegal annexation' should be construed by India in a positive light. [14] From this point on, the Chinese position began to gradually